



MAPPING OYSTER REEF HABITAT IN SOUTH CAROLINA

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Information for:

Resource Management
Marine Science
Conservation Efforts
Shellfish Industry
Coastal Adaptation

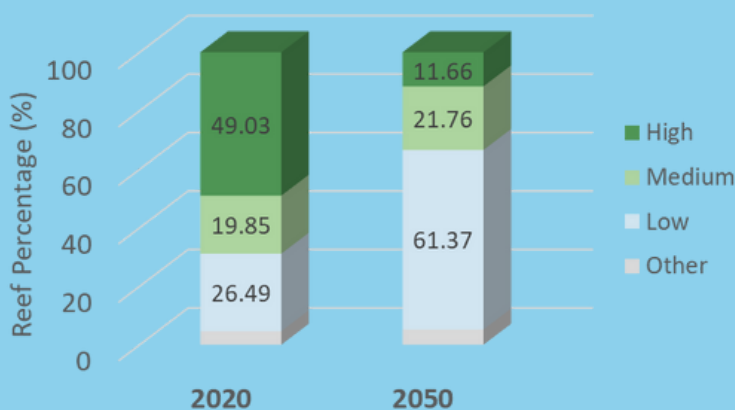
About the Project

A CORE SC 2024-25 Research Project in collaboration with the University of South Carolina, S.C. Department of Natural Resources, College of Charleston, and S.C. Sea Grant Consortium providing proof of concept for a geospatial approach that could be expanded along the South Carolina coast.

Project Objectives:

- Map the location of current oyster reefs in 2020 imagery.
- Develop an Elevational Suitability Index to predict future reef suitability.

OYSTER HABITAT SUITABILITY CHANGE MATRIX



2020-2050 change in suitability ranks of current oyster reefs

Results

In a future 1-ft sea level rise scenario current reefs at Folly Island will remain, but habitat suitability will be heavily affected. Current reefs are **clustered in lower elevation** making them more vulnerable to sea rise.

By 2050:

- 97% high ranking reefs downgraded
- 74% medium ranking reefs downgraded
- 61% of current reefs will be low suitability